

Dover, Morris County, New Jersey Blackwell Neighborhood Plan

Section 7: Proposed Vision, Strategies, Activities, and Outcomes



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Dover, Morris County, New Jersey

Blackwell Neighborhood Plan

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A. Vision

Residents and workers in the Blackwell neighborhood articulated a desire for a more activated and cohesive community. Youth in the Blackwell neighborhood desire more opportunities for recreation and connection. Community members expressed wants for more affordable housing that is accessible to existing residents and good jobs that support their lives in Dover. Climate resilience also came up as a concern, with residents reporting increased flooding in low-lying areas, disproportionately impacting senior residents.

Cognizant of community members' visions for their community, and the neighborhood's existing conditions, 5 categories of interventions are proposed in the neighborhood plan:

1. Community Cohesion
2. Affordable Housing
3. Mobility
4. Climate Resilience
5. Economic Development

The Blackwell neighborhood benefits from its vibrant and well-trafficked business corridors. The neighborhood as well as the broader Dover area host a dynamic and engaged network of community organizations, charities, and nonprofits committed to the residents of the town. The proposed strategies take the Blackwell neighborhood's baseline conditions and Norwescap's capacity as lead organization into account.



Figure 1:
Residents at the
Art in the Park
event on Aug 1, 2026

B. Proposed Strategies

Focus Area 1: Community Cohesion

During the first community meeting to discuss the plan, a resident said that there is a divide in Dover between new and old residents. Other community members talked about how there are fewer opportunities for youth activities in the town. Community cohesion and participation are primary requirements for any plan to be implemented. Residents need to feel invested in the future of the town to make efforts for or allow others to make efforts for its betterment.

Strategy 1: Stimulate community-driven neighborhood improvement

For community members in the Blackwell neighborhood to see the best possible outcomes of their plan, they need to be involved in the process to the point of driving it. This is not only important for this neighborhood plan to be successfully implemented, but also for future efforts to improve the neighborhood to be realized. Many community organizations have deep roots in Dover; namely the AMP Arts Center, the Partnership for Maternal and Child Health, Zufall Health, numerous churches, and more. This strategy leverages their existing social capital and involvement in local community issues.

The lead organization, Norwescap, can undertake the following actions:

- *Provide technical support to existing community events:*
Dover already has numerous avenues for engagement. Each community organization hosts its own series of events. The lead organization could provide support by helping set up the events - some of which are organized by only one person - or assisting with program facilitation.
- *Bilingual programming:* Dover is majority a Spanish-speaking area. For all residents to feel welcome, events need to be held bilingually.
- *Removing barriers to attendance:* Dover's largely immigrant population also faces vulnerabilities participating in the public sphere. Providing support from transportation to and from events, and childcare may remove some barriers to attendance. Additionally, more community members may feel inclined to participate if events are held in trusted spaces such as churches and schools.
- *Dedicated outreach team:* To ensure successful outreach efforts, a dedicated team with at least one staff member should be assembled. This team can keep an eye on outreach efforts and adjust operations to ensure maximum community involvement at each time.

Strategy 2: Public Space Activation

The Blackwell neighborhood has a lot of public spaces, but residents report that they are underutilized. They especially call out a need for more youth-oriented activities. The neighborhood benefits from well-maintained and walkable parks, which could be sites of more community engagement.

The lead organization, Norwescap, can undertake the following actions:

- *Organize youth-focused events:*
Young people in Dover lack opportunities for recreation and participation in public spaces. Setting up events such as free movies in the park could make the Blackwell neighborhood a more welcoming place for young adults and teenagers. This demographic is particularly important for the future of Dover and cultivating long-term community investment. Community members specifically wanted more programming at the Crescent Field park.
- *Placemaking:*
The Blackwell neighborhood has strong assets in its business corridors. Many food businesses are bustling. However, only a fraction of them have significant outdoor seating, lighting, and signage. Creating more outdoor seating for businesses can make public spaces and the streets more welcoming to all residents. It invites people into businesses, and creates an immediate sense of safety and community.
- *Increasing programming at public parks:*
The Blackwell neighborhood boasts beautiful and well-maintained parks which are frequented on some occasions, but could benefit from more regular programming. This would give community members more chances to interact and build positive connections with each other.

Strategy 3: Investment into Arts and Culture

The Blackwell neighborhood is culturally distinct from surrounding areas. Over half of its residents were born outside the United States. It has a large Spanish-speaking population from different regions of South and Central America. A quarter of its foreign-born population was born in Colombia, followed closely by populations from Guatemala and Mexico. This is visible and celebrated in the Blackwell neighborhood, particularly in the commercial areas. There are numerous restaurants and cultural organizations, such as Club Colombia, which are beloved community establishments. In addition to this, arts-focused organizations such as the AMP in the Richards building put together events and classes to promote the work of local cultural workers and encourage residents to engage with creative activities.

The lead organization can undertake the following actions:

- *Support local arts education:*
Organizations such as the AMP host numerous community events and act as venues for art and cultural education programming. This programming could be promoted or generally supported.
- *Murals and public art:*
The commercial corridor has some public art, but has the potential for more community-led art. This would increase community members' sense of belonging and cultural ties to the neighborhood.

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Focus Area 2: Affordable Housing

The Blackwell neighborhood has a renter-dominant housing market, with 70% of its households renting, more than half of them cost burdened (paying more than 30% of their income). Its housing stock is also very old. More than 60% of structures were built prior to 1960.

Community members want more affordable and accessible housing options for the population of the town already present. Dover has multiple active redevelopment and development plans, but is not receiving investment in affordable housing. Keeping the renter population in mind, a few strategies have been outlined:

Strategy 1: Create a community land trust from vacant lots

Many residents of Dover are renters. As housing is not just shelter, but also an asset, residents will benefit from policies promoting homeownership. During community meetings, the main property concern was vacant or unused lots. Areas around the Richards building (which houses the AMP Community Center), and the areas south of the River, and the closing Methodist Church are all vacant.

These underutilized areas could be brought into a land bank, where they could be donated to mission-driven developers to produce permanently affordable housing in a trust model. If the land is held in a trust, the costs of the property are far minimized. This could make homeownership accessible.

Discrete actions which Norwescap could spearhead:

- Work with the City of Dover to identify an organization capable of managing a land bank for vacant or otherwise distressed properties in the city. This organization would also act as a manager for a land trust.
- Promote homeownership opportunities as construction goes through. Norwescap could work with existing community partners to spread awareness about the community land trust and its benefits to residents.

Strategy 2: Tenant and immigration rights education

More than half of Dover's residents are foreign-born, and 7 in 10 are renters. This makes residents particularly vulnerable to uncertain housing arrangements. The poor quality of housing kept coming up during community meetings, and this strategy seeks to empower residents in taking action against poor conditions.

Specific actions Norwescap could conduct include:

- Providing training on tenant's rights for residents.
- Sharing resources to organizations providing legal support in the case of discriminatory and/or unsafe housing.
- Periodically assessing tenant's housing conditions along parameters of health and safety.

Strategy 3: Acquisition and Rehabilitation of Affordable Rental Properties

Rental units in distressed properties could significantly benefit from acquisition-rehabilitation assistance. Essentially, funds are provided to an entity to purchase (acquire) and then upgrade/maintain (rehab) a property, with a stipulation that the property is rented out below market rate. This might benefit the large properties in the northern triangle of the neighborhood, which community members called out during planning meetings. Additionally, the business district has many old properties which could benefit from structural upgrades and maintenance.

Specific actions Norwescap could conduct include:

- Putting together an inventory of rental properties that are distressed within the neighborhood boundary. This would help create a starting point from which to assess the scale of the property maintenance issues in the neighborhood. This inventory could also mark properties that are several decades old, which may have a historic significance to the town, even if they do not have any official historic designations.
- Selecting an organization with the financial and technical capacity to acquire and upgrade rental units.
- Administering funding for acquisition and rehabilitation to the selected entity, through NRTC grant funding.

Strategy 4: Homeownership Counseling

In addition to creating properties for homeownership, informing potential homebuyers and counseling them to prepare them for homeownership is a crucial support.

Specific actions Norwescap could conduct include:

- Partner with local organizations who are already providing homeownership counseling to expand their efforts.
- Conducting outreach about homeownership counseling to reach more residents.

Focus Area 3: Mobility

Conveniently located at the last stop of New Jersey Transit's Morris and Essex line, the Blackwell neighborhood has a high potential to become more of a bustling transit stop. As a major node in the rail system, the neighborhood is also fairly walkable, with a diverse array of amenities and businesses closely located near the station. Residents are concerned about fast automobiles and safety for children, and also have concerns about limited parking around the commercial corridors. Improving mobility not only improves the ability to get around the neighborhood, but also encourages lingering in the neighborhood's public spaces.

Strategy 1: Transit Station Design

The Dover NJ Transit station is protected under the National Register of Historic Places¹. It has the potential to be more inviting to residents and visitors alike. The station itself is not the easiest to get to, with pedestrian crossings that could be safer. The waiting area also could be better maintained, with scope for a cafe or a few vending machines to operate there.

NJ Transit provides [guidance on Transit Oriented Development](#) around its stations. It lists components of transit-oriented development in suburban areas, which the lead organization could organize actions around:

- *"Sidewalks accommodate all types of users and serves as a buffer on busy roads. Open spaces are within walking distance of the transit facility, and are landscaped or paved for active or passive uses."*

The Blackwell neighborhood park facilities are nearby the station, but sidewalks and crossings need to be spruced up. The main crosswalks aren't easily visible to automobiles. Commissioning and implementing a redesign of the pedestrian area around the station would improve its safety and accessibility.

- *"The transit facility may be the focal point of the community and should use design elements that are representative of the quality of service and the identity of the place. Both large and small transit shelters may be utilized."*

Dover's station is not open and faces maintainance issues which can be addressed.

In 2006, Dover created a [Transit Oriented Development plan](#) as well, which this neighborhood plan strategy would be in alignment with.

1 https://content.njtransit.com/sites/default/files/tod/TFP_Guide_2022.pdf p. 61

Strategy 2: Safe Streets

Children in Dover are vulnerable to fast automobiles driving around the neighborhood. Parents report concerns about street safety, especially as their children play on the street. Safer sidewalk designs help other community members who frequent the neighborhood and business district as well.

The National Association of City Transportation Officials (NACTO) lists [street design guidelines](#) to [slow down vehicular traffic](#). Selected guidelines may benefit the town of Dover and the Blackwell neighborhood area:

- *Crosswalk infrastructure*: Ensuring crosswalk painting is maintained allows for consistent and clear visibility of crossing areas. Some areas on Blackwell street have crosswalks between intersections which are not clearly demarcated. These areas would benefit especially from more signage and button-operated crossing signals.
- *Sidewalk infrastructure*: Implementing bulb-outs at major crossings will increase visibility of pedestrians and narrow the area for vehicular turns, encouraging slow movement. Additionally, parklets on cross streets of East Blackwell Street would benefit bustling businesses there and serve to nudge vehicles to be more cautious while driving there. Additionally, some sidewalks do not have curb cuts, which make them inaccessible to people with limited mobility.

The Neighborhood Plan implementation could include actions such as identifying priority infrastructure improvements and a design and construction team to carry them out.

Strategy 3: Intentional Parking Opportunities

While the Blackwell neighborhood is accessible by walking, surrounding areas of Morris County and the rest of the town are not. To get more attention and customers to local businesses, the Blackwell neighborhood revitalization efforts need to include more parking at strategic locations. During outreach events, residents discussed a prohibitive lack of parking facilities in the commercial corridor.

The lead organization can collaborate with the town of Dover to adjust its parking facilities:

- *Diagonal on-street Parking*: Street parking is the easiest opportunity to slow down vehicular traffic and provide options for patrons to park. The Blackwell Street area already has plenty of on-street parking, but it could be tilted to diagonal parking to increase the volume of vehicles able to park. The resultant narrowing streets will also serve to slow down traffic.
- *Paid parking*: Revenues from parking could be directed to neighborhood improvement activities, providing another layer of benefits to the neighborhood.

Focus Area 4: Climate Resilience

Climate change is an urgent matter which impacts the habitability the built environment, and influences the conditions for a community's social and economic flourishing. In 2025, Morris County created its Multijurisdictional Hazard Mitigation Plan. It included an [annex for Dover](#), listing specific troubling vulnerabilities which may be addressed through green and grey interventions. The Blackwell neighborhood has sidewalks which are very hot, and during summer months, discourage walking. The neighborhood also contains the Rockaway River, which is reported to flood regularly, and harm senior, low-income residents the most. A future-forward neighborhood revitalization plan includes considerations of climate vulnerability, and proactive measures can make the community more environmentally, socially, and economically resilient.

Strategy 1: Flood Hazard Mitigation

The major vulnerability residents and community members identified in public meetings was flooding. Morris County lists 52 properties that had suffered from repetitive flood losses and 20 from severe repetitive flood losses. As Dover has a population below 20,000, a significant proportion of the town is impacted.

Norwescap could lead the following actions:

- *Nature-based Riparian Buffer Solutions:* The area around the Rockaway River does not have a significant [buffer](#) between the river's edge and development areas. This suffocates the natural mechanisms through which flooding is mediated. As the neighborhood is densely developed, it is difficult to remediate this buffer. Additionally, the Morris County report states that impacted buildings are older multi-family homes for which elevation would be infeasible¹. However, planting thicker greenery and replacing concretized/asphalt materials on parking structures by the river increase the permeability of soil by the river's edge. This creates areas for rising water to sink in instead of flowing across the ground's surface and spreading to more properties. The River also has a potential to become an asset, a green space which could stimulate more community connection to the neighborhood
- *Climate-Sensitive Urban Design:* Leveraging [urban design strategies](#) such as bioswales, flow-through planters, pervious strips, and pervious pavements could serve the dual benefit of mediating flood risk and beautifying the streets further.

¹ https://www.morriscountynj.gov/files/sharedassets/public/v/1/departments/office-of-emergency-mngmt/mitigation-plan-2025/18_town-of-dover-annex.pdf, pg. 11.

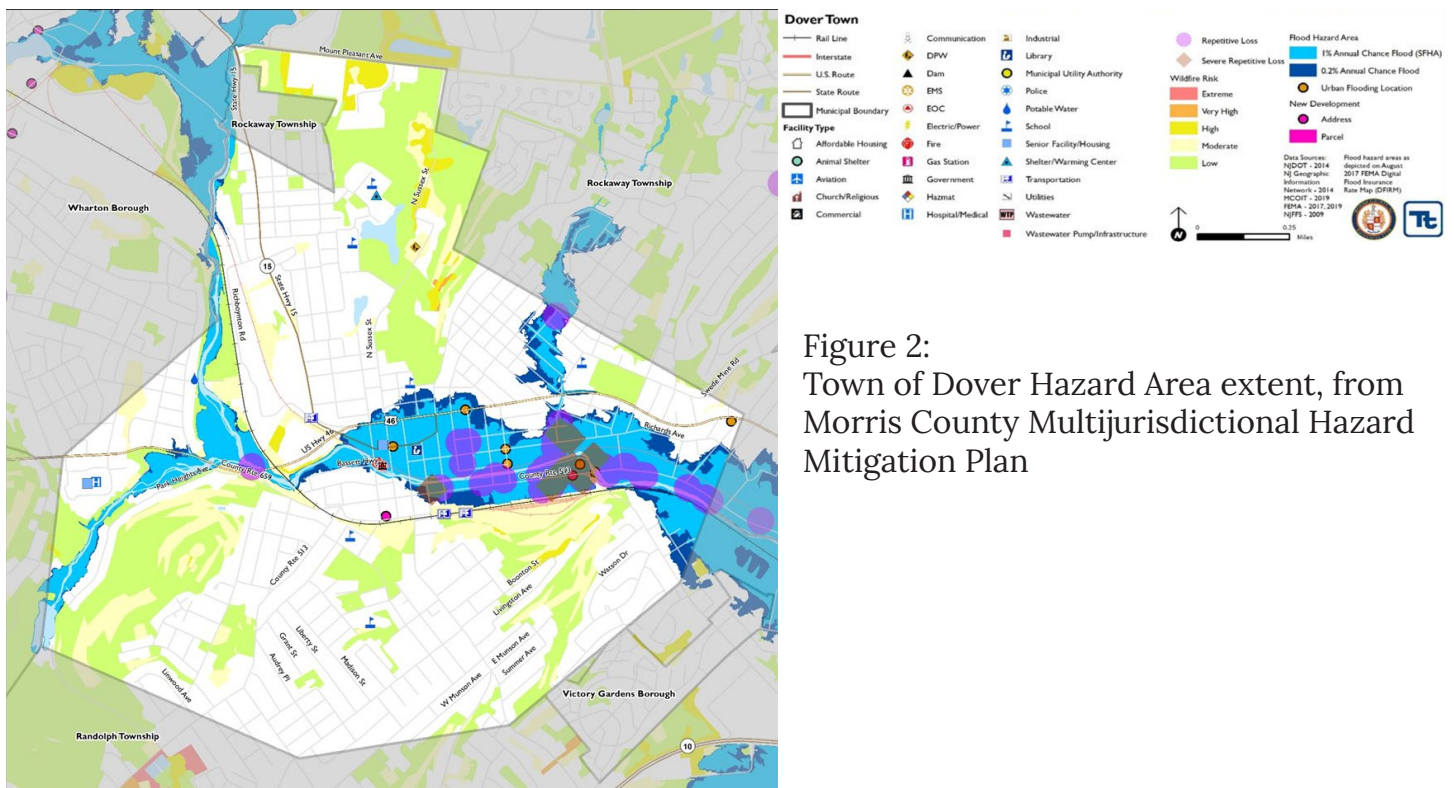


Figure 2:
Town of Dover Hazard Area extent, from
Morris County Multijurisdictional Hazard
Mitigation Plan

Strategy 2: Urban Heat Island Mitigation

The Blackwell neighborhood and the whole town of Dover are very built up. While development is generally low or medium-rise, individual properties are close together, leading to high concretization. This contributes to the [Urban Heat Island effect](#), whereby development reverses the temperature moderating effects of natural surfaces and vegetation. As shown in Figure 3, Dover and the Blackwell neighborhood faced extremely high land surface temperatures (LST) during the summer of 2022.

Norwescap could lead the following actions:

- **Community tree planting events:** Trees planted in urban or suburban areas have numerous benefits. They provide shade, nourish the natural ecosystems, and beautify the area. This is recognized in the town of Dover, which has had a [Shade Tree Commission](#) since 1974. Tree planting events could be organized in collaboration with the Shade Tree Commission to bring out residents and stimulate more local participation in improving the neighborhood.
- **Implementing microclimate interventions:** Minimally invasive interventions such as creating community gardens, shaded bus stops, and water stations require less effort in installing, but directly benefit the neighborhood climate. The New Jersey Board of Public Utilities [encourages](#) these types of interventions to target extreme heat.

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The Urban Heat Island Effect and Land Surface Temperature in New Jersey

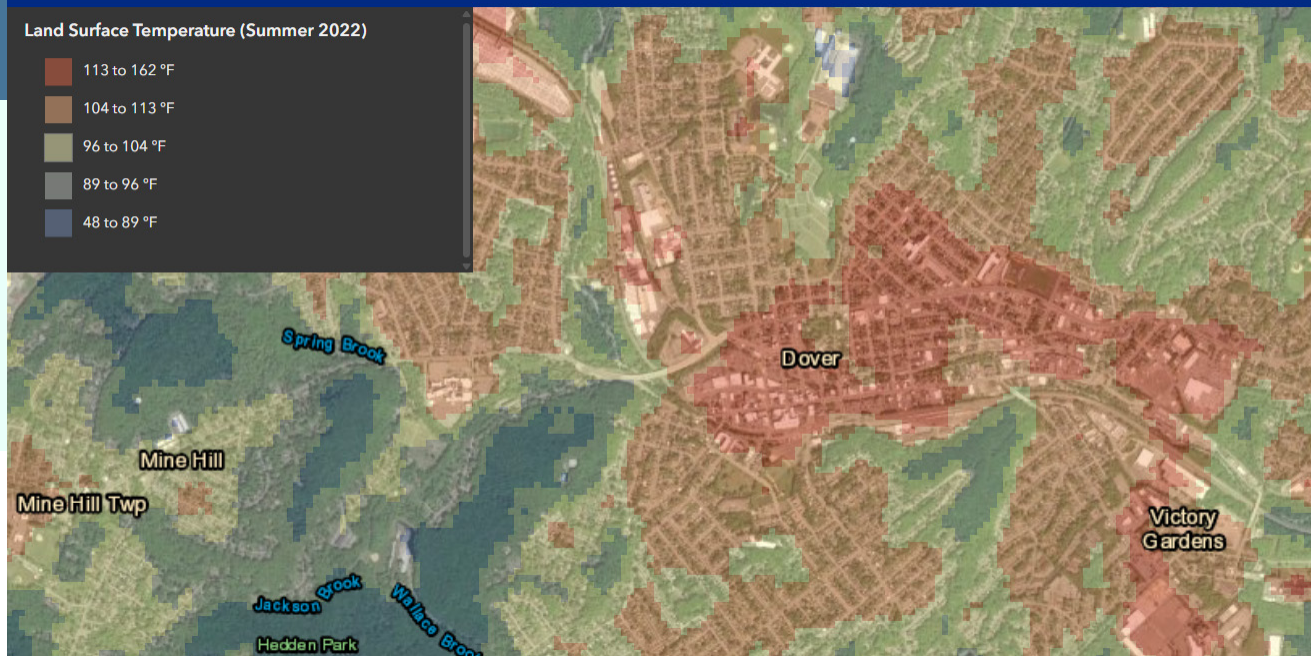


Figure 3:
Screenshot from New Jersey Department of Environmental Protection's [Urban Heat Island Mapping tool](#).

Strategy 3: Community Gardens

Neighborhood community members report that nutrition and food access remain persistent problems for the Blackwell neighborhood. Organizations such as Zufall Health, Partnership for Maternal and Child Health, and Nourish NJ operate in or around the neighborhood, seeking to meet resident needs. Planting community gardens in the neighborhood could increase high-quality produce availability to residents, reduce their reliance on non-local food sources, and promote community health.

Norwescap could lead the following actions:

- *Shortlist sites:* Identifying sites large enough to host gardens is the first step towards food sovereignty.
- *Provide materials:* Providing resources such as organic fertilizers would help maintain community gardens.
- *Arrange technical requirements and documentation:* Site insurance and other documentation could be provided to support community gardens.

Strategy 4: Community Health

Blackwell neighborhood residents face uncertain access to health. Many residents who are foreign-born face limited, and changing access to public insurance. A third of the neighborhood lacks health insurance. Climate change impacts health as well, so residents that are already vulnerable face increased health risks. This strategy calls for the lead organization to support existing activities of local community health organizations.

Focus Area 5: Economic Development

The Blackwell neighborhood already has a very bustling commercial corridor which lends the neighborhood its unique character. This prosperity is not realized among all residents. The neighborhood's median income is half of that of the state, and nearly a third of the county median income. Keeping this in mind, neighborhood revitalization strategies aimed at economic development will be geared towards workforce development and stimulating the creation of "Good Jobs".

Strategy 1: Workforce Development Programs and Education

Industry trends in the neighborhood deviate from the town, county, and state. The three major sectors in Dover are Administrative and support and waste management services, Manufacturing, and Construction. In combination, they account for almost half the town's population. The sector of Professional, scientific, and technical services takes up less than a percent of the neighborhood's industry breakdown, when this figure is 4% and 13% for the town and county respectively. This is reflected in education disparities in the town as well: a third of residents have not completed high school. 22% of the population 25-54 years old is unemployed in the Blackwell neighborhood. Community members report that residents do not have access to work opportunities. Community input and the data underscore the need for workforce development and training programs.

Norwescap could lead the following actions to support workforce development:

- *Providing Professional Certificate Courses:* This could be conducted in collaboration with County College of Morris (CCM) which is active in Dover.
- *Worker rights education:* Norwescap already conducts labor rights education programming. These activities could be expanded.

Strategy 2: Create and Preserve "Good Jobs"

Community members reported that there are jobs in Dover, but not many "Good Jobs". There are numerous staffing agencies in the neighborhood, but they are not serving resident needs. Some community members even asked around for work opportunities at community meetings, highlighting the urgency of the neighborhood's unemployment.

The lead organization could take the following actions:

- *Access to capital for microenterprises:* With the high unemployment rate in the neighborhood, stimulating self-employment could empower residents. Access to capital for setting up microenterprises could help create jobs for the entrepreneurs as well as support other neighborhood residents.
- *Priority contracting opportunities:* Construction is a large sector in Dover. As developers eye the Blackwell neighborhood area, there will be more construction opportunities, which could prioritize local labor.

C. NRTC Investment and Opportunity

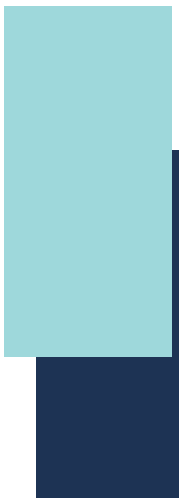
This neighborhood plan seeks to provide strategies that both cushion and springboard the Blackwell neighborhood: socially, culturally, environmentally, and economically. It outlines strategies across multiple domains: housing, public space and placemaking, connectivity and mobility, environmental resilience, and economic development. It was created through a community-led effort, bringing together local organizations and general community members.

Section 6 of the plan outlines community assets. The neighborhood is a vibrant community with a distinct character. Nearly all residents identify as Hispanic, many from culturally rich regions of Colombia, Guatemala, and Mexico. In addition to that, the built features of the Blackwell neighborhood have been preserved and add a historic flair to the neighborhood. Its connectivity via the NJ Transit station and walkability also serve as huge assets, promoting economic resilience. It is also receiving development interest, with multiple redevelopment efforts underway while the plan was being formulated. This plan seeks to build on these assets and maximise outcomes for the communities present locally.

The lead organization for this revitalization effort, Norwescap, is uniquely positioned as an organization with both hyperlocal and broad geographic focuses. Norwescap operates over multiple counties in the Northwest of New Jersey, and is already implementing two neighborhood plans with vastly different mandates and interventions. It already has relationships with organizations that could help implement plan strategies through these other NRTC plans, which support the odds of this plan's successful implementation. Moreover, it has cultivated close working relationships with community members and trusted community institutions such as the library, churches, and local nonprofits. This positions Norwescap as an organization capacitated to lead positive change in the neighborhood while aligning itself closely with community interests.

Local partners such as the AMP, County College of Morris, Zufall Health, Partnership for Maternal and Child Health also provide crucial community and social services, which this plan is aware of and seeks to expand.

Leading with community direction and our organizational capacity, we are confident in implementing a neighborhood revitalization strategy that will benefit and empower the Blackwell neighborhood.



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